

FIRST CLASS

TRAVELLING IN STYLE

EDITOR: ALEXANDRA SPRING

THE GREAT ESCAPE

Whether it's PAMPERING, pummelling or simply *time out*, *ESCAPE* means different things to different people. Choose your own *adventure* from this guide to Australia's most gorgeous *GETAWAYS*. Photographed by Lincoln Pilcher.

STYLIST: MORGAN PILCHER HAIR: KENNA KENNOR
MAKE-UP: STEVIE HUYNH MODEL: AVA SMITH

QUALIA, HAMILTON ISLAND, QUEENSLAND



The ethos: Serious world-class luxury in a sublime setting.

Prime candidate: For sun-seeking spa-goers looking for an ultra-private getaway, Qualia lives up to its description as a “discreet retreat”.

What to expect: Miranda Kerr “loved every minute” of her stay, calling Hamilton Island “one of the most beautiful places on earth”. And she’s not the only one. Qualia (pronounced kwah-lee-ah), which in Latin translates to “a collection of deeper sensory experiences”, was voted the Best Resort in the World 2012 in the *Condé Nast Traveler* Readers’ Choice Awards. If you’ve ever visited, you’ll know why its standards are suited to that of a glamorous supermodel: the resort is pure luxury. No wonder the likes of Oprah Winfrey, designer Donna Karan, model Anja Rubik and actor Naomi Watts have also stayed here.

From the moment you arrive, the Qualia experience begins. You’re handed a glass of Veuve Clicquot, along with the keys to your own personal golf buggy. The rooms feature private plunge pools and sweeping views of the Coral Sea, viewed through fragrant Australian eucalyptus trees. The food is exceptional and you can choose from one of two restaurants. Do a little or a lot – it’s up to you. A vast range of activities is on offer from sailing around the Whitsundays to scenic flights around the glorious islands. If you’re planning a family break, however, this isn’t the place for you. It’s strictly for those aged over 16 only, so expect serious peace and quiet. Read between the lines: this is the ultimate romantic retreat.

Don’t miss: The signature experiences such as personal beach drop-offs with a picnic lunch, or a couple’s treatment at the spa. The Sweet Moments treatment comes highly recommended. And wine lovers should sample a drop from Robert Oatley Vineyards. Qualia’s Australian owner Bob Oatley is a man of many talents: both an award-winning sailor and an exceptional

winemaker. Our pick is Wild Oats Rosé 2012. Perfect for sunset drinks by the sea. **Added incentive:** Spa Qualia Experience luxury package rates start at \$2,666.

Go to: www.qualia.com.au.

GEORGIE ABAY

HAYMAN ISLAND, GREAT BARRIER REEF, QUEENSLAND



The ethos: Relaxation in style, where healthy living and luxury are balanced and customised to your needs.

Prime candidate: For those who like to mix their pool lounge lazing with good food, exploration and a dash of pampering. **What to expect:** If your idea of an indulgent dream getaway doesn’t include negotiating customs and immigration, Hayman is the destination for you. Set against the spectacular Great Barrier Reef, on the northernmost island in the Whitsunday passage, the private escape is the ideal place to drop out and get back in touch with mind and body. It’s impossible not to melt into a state of hyper-relaxation when faced with the picture-perfect backdrop of white sand, palm trees, endless sky and tropical blue waters.

And when you tire of staring at the horizon, there are water sports to be dabbled in, a coral reef to explore, wildlife to discover, and hampers to be enjoyed on a day-trip picnic to one of the surrounding islands.

If exploring your own state of mind is more your pace, Hayman offers the Spa and Wellness program. Wellness therapist Ryko Kalinko has travelled the world studying natural healing methods and draws from ayurvedic, Taoist, Hawaiian kahuna, Maori, Australian indigenous, Hermetic, and Kabbalist traditions. His easygoing approach to health will have you quickly succumbing to a serene mind-set. Kalinko is the first to admit this journey is designed for indulgence, alongside learning about simple ways to keep well.

While you can detox here, prepare to be tempted. The delicious, freshly prepared

food available at one of the four restaurants at the resort will make it hard to resist.

For an energising way to start the day, try open-air yoga, tai chi or chi gong with the dew-soaked grass between your toes and the sun rising over the Coral Sea.

Don’t miss: The DVF penthouse, fitted out by Diane von Furstenberg, or a beach villa for reach-out-and-touch ocean frontage.

Added incentive: *Vogue* readers who book a Hayman Spa & Wellness Program will receive a complimentary upgrade to a suite. Contact Hayman reservations for details.

Go to www.hayman.com.au.

GENEVRA LEEK

THE BYRON AT BYRON, BYRON BAY, NEW SOUTH WALES



The ethos: Laid-back luxury.

Prime candidate: Crowd-sensitive types and those craving peace.

What to expect: The problem with Byron Bay is that everyone and their downward dog goes there to relax now. In a town that attracts sea-changers, backpackers and yoga teachers like moths to an aromatherapy candle, it’s getting harder to escape. But the Byron at Byron, spread across 45 acres of lush rainforest, with its own stretch of beach, is just five minutes drive from town. Sip a glass of Bollinger on the verandah that overlooks an infinity pool lined with white daybeds; or check in to the spa for a Pevonia Botanics facial.

Don’t miss: Complimentary daily yoga sessions by the pool. Or try the Byron Iced Tea; a shot of lychee syrup with two shots of jasmine tea and a dash each of lemon juice and sugar syrup over ice and garnished with mint and cucumber.

Added incentive: The Byron is offering *Vogue* readers two nights in a one-bedroom suite with a daily buffet breakfast, daily yoga, late checkout and 10 per cent off spa treatments. From \$660 for two nights. Valid for bookings until September 17, 2013.

Go to www.thebyronatbyron.com.au.

SIGOURNEY CANTELO

LINCOLN PILCHER

MIX YOUR POOL LOUNGE LAZING WITH GOOD FOOD, EXPLORATION AND A DASH OF PAMPERING

SOUTHERN OCEAN LODGE, KANGAROO ISLAND, SOUTH AUSTRALIA



The ethos: Prepare to be spoilt in one of the world's most unspoilt locations.

Prime candidate: Anyone looking to escape their day-to-day life.

What to expect: Kangaroo Island is a 25-minute flight from Adelaide, then, depending on the time of day and therefore the wildlife on the road, about a one-hour drive to what feels like the end of the earth – in a good way. The spectacular structure on the island's south-western corner was opened in 2008 by James and Hayley Baillie, owners of Baillie Luxury Lodges. And, unsurprisingly, the lodge's most famous asset is its stunning coastal views. Guests are encouraged to feel as if they're staying in the home of a friend. Even the most cynical city dweller can get into the mindset of the no-key, no-locked-door approach. Activities include walks, canapés with the kangaroos and gastronomic tours. At day's end, the turndown service means more than just rearranged bed sheets. The warm gas fire, fragrant candles, soft music and gentle lighting are enough to inspire a similar night-time ritual at home.

Don't miss: The boardwalk over the cliffs to arrive at the Southern Spa, a spectacularly located day spa. Allow your therapist to cover you in the island's famously pure Ligurian honey and locally sourced salts. Finish with a rain shower above the cliffs looking over the ocean.

Added incentive: *Vogue* readers who book four nights at Southern Ocean Lodge/Baillies Lodges receive one complimentary night's stay, a take-home hamper of local epicurean treats and a \$100 Southern Spa voucher. From \$2,970 per person for stays until September 30, 2013.

Go to southernoceanlodge.com.au.

ALEXANDRA BROWN

EDEN HEALTH RETREAT, GOLD COAST, QUEENSLAND



The ethos: Restore your mind, body and soul with a holistic approach to treatments. **Prime candidate:** The tired and stressed who want to detox, ditch a bad habit or hit the restore button and rejuvenate while learning about lasting lifestyle changes.

What to expect: Formerly known as Camp Eden, the Eden Health Retreat has undergone a multi-million dollar refurbishment and stepped away from its boot-camp beginnings. The famous flying fox ride through the forest is still on offer but not compulsory. One thing that hasn't changed is the holistic approach to healing mind, body and spirit through individual therapies, workshops, fitness classes, meditation, spa treatments and nutritional advice from resident naturopath Blair Harvey.

They say that everyone gets naked sooner or later at Eden. Try a Hawaiian kahuna massage in a tiny wooden massage cabin tucked into a leafy hillside, then join fellow retreaters in the communal dining hall to share lunch. They are a friendly bunch, wildly diverse in age, background, health and their reasons for coming, yet united in their desire for personal transformation. The food is delicious, inventive, abundant and second only to the stunning scenery of the surrounding Currumbin Valley rainforest, said to have been an Aboriginal healing ground.

Don't miss: Club Mud: smother yourself in healing benzonite clay then sunbake in a deck chair before washing it off in the outdoor shower; cycling through the lush green valley to a local organic farm, the flying fox and, most of all, the food.

Added incentive: *Vogue* readers who mention this article can receive a 30 per cent discount on a five- or seven-night stay in any cabin style (pending availability).

Go to www.edenhealthretreat.com.au.

JODY SCOTT



PREPARE TO BE
SPOILT IN ONE OF
THE WORLD'S
MOST UNSPOILT
LOCATIONS

SAFFIRE FREYCINET, FREYCINET PENINSULA, TASMANIA



The ethos: Return to nature and breathe in – and deeply. Tasmania has some of the cleanest air in the world.

Prime candidate: City dwellers who need enforced relaxation but are not willing to sacrifice urban luxuries like fine dining.

What to expect: Classic with a modern – and decidedly Tasman – twist. The location ensures panoramic views of the majestic Hazard Range and the white-sand Cole Beach that will induce anyone into a state of relaxation. The Saffire spa takes the holistic approach to health, with an

emphasis more on wellbeing than beauty. The spa area is designed to face a private garden rather than the view of the national park, to encourage visitors to look within and focus on themselves. Private yoga and pilates classes can be organised, and Saffire recently introduced the e-Tox package, which banishes digital devices throughout your stay. Spa treatments include classic services as well as hot stones using polished pink granite from the Hazards.

Don't miss: The degustation dinner with matching wines at Palate restaurant by award-winning executive chef Hugh Whitehouse is a highlight. Expect fresh Tasmanian produce executed with classic French techniques, such as kangaroo, oysters and truffles – a detox resort this is not. Visit the Freycinet Marine Oyster Farm and dine on fresh Pacific oysters with sparkling Tasmanian wine while standing (in waders) in the Great Oyster Bay.

Added incentive: Two-night e-Tox deals start at \$3,600 a person and include meals, dinner drinks and a Downtime massage.

Go to www.saffire-freycinet.com.au.

ZARA WONG

ECO BEACH, BROOME, WESTERN AUSTRALIA



The ethos: Eco Beach is all about treading lightly but luxuriously. Designed and operated on ecological principles, the resort champions sustainable luxury and the appreciation of the glorious bush and beach surroundings.

Prime candidate: Those who want to truly escape from the madding crowd.

What to expect: Just over an hour's drive from Broome, Eco Beach is remote. And yet there is more than enough to do (if so inclined) with a sandy swimming beach, bush walks, visiting whales, a spa sanctuary,

top notch food and unforgettable sunsets. Start the day rising with the crickets and watching the majestic sunrise from the deck of your luxurious beachfront eco villa or eco tent. There's complimentary yoga in the Dragonfly pavilion each morning, where guests stretch opposite a distractingly beautiful view of the cove.

As the day warms up, there's idling to be done in the infinity pool or relaxing in the spa with a Swedish massage, reiki or the surprisingly helpful life alignment. Alternatively, an exploratory bushwalk can lead to the caves for some truly unique meditation. And as the sun sinks back down again, why not enjoy a five-star dinner with a Rusty Kimberley Sunset cocktail followed by a starlit stroll back to the villa and blissed-out sleep? Eco Beach is a healthy prod towards the restorative effects of Mother Nature and it will make you more determined to breathe deeply, wriggle your toes in the grass and pause to look up at the stars.

Don't miss: Jack's Creek, a short off-road drive from the resort. The creek runs parallel to the beach and when the tide ►



LINCOLN PILCHER

is out the creek bed becomes a fascinating walking trail as tiny crabs and critters pick up their shells and skitter across the sand. It's also the perfect spot to enjoy the silliness of Mud 'n' Bubbles – sipping champagne while wearing the ultra-moisturising mangrove mud.

Added incentive: Eco Beach is offering a 20 per cent discount to *Vogue* readers.

Go to www.ecobeach.com.au.

ALEXANDRA SPRING

LAKE HOUSE, DAYLESFORD, VICTORIA



The ethos: When in doubt, take to the waters.

Prime candidate: Water babies, foodies and locavores.

What to expect: Mineral hydrotherapy and gastronomic adventure in a stylish, storybook setting. Spread along the edge of the charming, oh-so-Euro Lake Daylesford, Lake House offers chic yet homely accommodation with a focus on fine local food and relaxation.

Known as Victoria's spa country, Daylesford and sister town Hepburn Springs boast the largest number of naturally occurring mineral springs in Australia and are responsible for 85 per cent of Australia's bottled water. Swiss Italians settled in the area after the gold rush, as it reminded them of home. There are multiple pumps around the area from which local devotees draw water to drink and bathe in, claiming its high mineral content can cure any ailment from eczema to arthritis. At Lake House's Salus Spa the mineral water is heated and piped into deep geisha tubs in private one-person treehouses. Neck deep in effervescent mineral-rich water, you can open the shutters and admire the pretty vignette of leaves and dappled Renoiresque light.

vogueESCAPE

While Lake Daylesford is a little smaller than Lake Como, the setting is magnificent. With picturesque bridges, curious geese and shimmering inlets that turn gold at sunset, it's the perfect alternative to a coastal escape.

Enjoy the view along with the best local produce in the Lake House restaurant, which was awarded two hats by *The Age Food Guide* and celebrates hearty seasonal fare like rabbit cassoulet, forest mushrooms and local goat's cheese.

Don't miss: For a special occasion or a family escape, book the Retreat, a two-bedroom private house with fireplaces, cashmere throws, deep baths, an outdoor spa and firepit. Spa manager Sera Tan says you can recreate a hydrotherapy experience in your bathroom. Do a full body salt scrub then soak in a bath sprinkled with Epsom salts and lavender flowers. The salts will dissolve in the water and the oil will hydrate, leaving a dewy glow to the skin.

Added incentive: A two-night escape with daily breakfast and one night's dinner is \$448 per person.

Go to www.lakehouse.com.au.

SIGOURNEY CANTELO

EMIRATES WOLGAN VALLEY RESORT & SPA, BLUE MOUNTAINS, NEW SOUTH WALES



The ethos: Head for the hills; life is peaceful there.

Prime candidate: Visiting internationals and strung-out execs who need to reconnect with the land.

What to expect: From the moment you hand your keys to the valet and step aboard the four-wheel drive transfer (the roads around the property are too hairy for city slickers to navigate) to the homestead, there's a sense of unplugging: cutting the cords of corporate rigour, escaping urban ennui and reconnecting with the land.

Nestled in the Greater Blue Mountains three hours' drive west of Sydney in a verdant valley between two heritage-protected national parks, Wolgan Valley is like a sparkling, wildlife-studded advertisement for Australia. The sprawling property is encircled by prehistoric Gondwanaland cliffs and dense scrub filled with fragrant eucalypts and curious kangaroos.

Owned by Emirates airline, the 40 freestanding suites and the ambling homestead (which houses the two restaurants and reception) are on a level of luxury normally reserved for six-star hotels in Dubai. The villas have every creature comfort a sybarite could dream up: double-sided fireplaces, private indoor/outdoor lap pools, rocking chairs on a mosquito-netted deck, heavenly baths with a view out to the wilderness, giant walk-in wardrobes, binoculars and mountain bikes.

The resort is the world's first zero-carbon-certified hotel and was built using reclaimed materials where possible. Emirates has also planted a small forest of indigenous trees and insists on only using regional and seasonal food sourced from within a 160 kilometre radius. You can do as much (horse-riding/mountain biking/bird-watching) or as little as you like.

Don't miss: A treatment at the Timeless Spa. A stunning example of eco-minded design, the spa displays found objects from the land's previous incarnation as a family farm, such as former fence posts and tiny, ancient bottles of Chinese Royal Jelly that were unearthed in the resort's construction. Floor-to-ceiling windows in the treatment rooms create a natural amphitheatre to absorb the epic wonder of the environment.

Executive chef Anston Fivaz's menu for the three restaurants and private dining service utilises a carefully curated list of local suppliers, and he encourages guests to visit these producers and take a little slice of local gastronomy home. "Buy regional, seasonal and organic," he says. "Try the Mudgee shiraz or an Orange pinot noir with some Jannei goat's cheese, Mandagery Creek venison or the Ormiston pork."

Added incentive: Wolgan Valley is offering a winter escape. Save \$500 per person on a two-night luxurious winter getaway to Emirates Wolgan Valley Resort & Spa, priced from \$725 per person, per night. Valid from July 1 to September 15, 2013. Priced based on twin-share.

Go to www.wolganvalley.com.

SIGOURNEY CANTELO